



Cartoon of Paris Commune, 1871

In 1871 a revolutionary government, the Commune, briefly seized power in Paris. Marx had no influence on the uprising, but hailed it as “the glorious harbinger of a new society.”

industrial workers, inspired to rise up against the capitalists who exploited their labor, could be the vehicle for revolutionary change. In 1847, Marx and Engels both joined a small subversive organization known as the League of the Just, soon renamed the Communist League. For this they wrote *The Communist Manifesto*, a powerful appeal for the overthrow of society by a worldwide workers’ revolution. It was a timely document, for in 1848 there were revolts in many cities across Europe, including Paris, Berlin, and Vienna. Marx contributed to the agitation with his writings, though neither he nor the Communist League had any significant impact on events. After the suppression of the uprisings in 1849, life for radicals such as Marx became impossible in continental Europe. He moved to Britain, a relatively liberal country that was tolerant of the activities of political refugees.

Theorizing revolution

In the 1850s the prospect of a triumph for the workers’ revolution seemed remote, and the Communist League withered away. Marx instead devoted himself to an immense theoretical effort, intended to place the revolutionary critique of capitalist society on a secure scientific and philosophical basis. Although he earned some money from journalism, Marx did not work to support himself and his growing family, depending mostly on handouts from Engels. Thus he was free to write full-time, becoming a familiar presence in the British Museum Reading Room in London. The major result of his labors was the first volume of his analysis of capitalism, *Das Kapital*, in 1867.

By then Marx had resumed practical political activity. In 1864 he joined the International Working Men’s



Association, an attempt to coordinate the efforts of assorted left-wing groups. Marx immediately established himself as a dominant force in the group,



The Communist Manifesto

The *Manifesto* of 1848 is the most succinct statement of Marx’s and Engels’ ideas.

but his inability to tolerate the views of those who did not share his own ideas led to conflicts. When a revolutionary Commune briefly took control of Paris in 1871 (an uprising provoked by France’s defeat in war with Prussia) the International played only the most marginal role in events. Yet after Marx wrote a pamphlet in praise of the uprising, the

International received much of the blame (or credit) for it, giving Marx unprecedented notoriety.

Still, there was no reason in the last decade of Marx’s life to suppose that he would become one of the most

Radical journalism

Marx (left) and Engels (center) collaborate on the *Neue Rheinische Zeitung*, a radical newspaper that they edited in 1848–49, a time of revolutionary upheaval in Europe. Marx was an excellent journalist, writing with humor and style as well as insightful political analysis.

“The **workers** have nothing to **lose**... but their **chains**.”

KARL MARX, FROM *THE COMMUNIST MANIFESTO*, 1848

influential figures in history. His writings, combining German philosophy and economic analysis, were often dauntingly intellectual. Yet a conviction spread that Marx had proved the inevitability of the fall of capitalism and of a workers’ revolution. After his death, Marxism was adopted as a belief system by revolutionary groups, and became the official ideology of states such as the Soviet Union and Communist China. What Marx himself would have thought of the actions carried out in his name we cannot know, although Engels claimed that Marx once declared: “I am not a Marxist.”



IDEA

COMMUNISM

Marx saw history as a struggle between social classes. In 19th-century Europe, the bourgeoisie, or middle class, owned the means of production—factories and machinery. By paying the working class (proletariat) less than their labor was worth, the bourgeoisie accumulated capital. Laws and government were arranged to defend their power. According to communist ideals, it was the historic role of the working class to carry out a revolution, establishing a “dictatorship of the proletariat” and creating a classless society free of exploitation or want.

TIMELINE

- **May 5, 1818** Karl Marx is born in Trier, on the lower Rhine.
- **1835** Studies law at the University of Bonn.
- **1836** Moves to the Friedrich-Wilhelms-Universität in Berlin, where he studies for five years, leaving with a doctorate.
- **1842** Marx becomes editor of the *Rheinische Zeitung* newspaper in Cologne; it is shut down the following year because of his radical articles.
- **June 19, 1843** Marries Prussian aristocrat’s daughter Jenny von Westphalen.
- **October 1843** Moves to Paris.
- **August 28, 1844** Friedrich Engels meets Marx in Paris and shows him his work on *The Condition of the Working Class in England*; their lifelong collaboration begins.
- **January 1845** Expelled from Paris, Marx and Engels move to Brussels, Belgium.
- **1847** Marx and Engels join the Communist League; Marx publishes *The Poverty of Philosophy*, a critique of French anarchist Pierre-Joseph Proudhon’s *The Philosophy of Poverty*.
- **February 21, 1848** *The Communist Manifesto* is published.
- **March 1848** Arrested and expelled from Brussels, Marx moves to Paris, where a revolution has overthrown the monarchy.
- **June 1848–May 1849** Marx returns to Cologne and edits a radical newspaper, the *Neue Rheinische Zeitung*; when the paper is suppressed he returns to Paris.
- **August 1849** Again expelled from Paris, Marx moves to London, where he settles for the rest of his life.
- **1852** Becomes London correspondent of the *New York Daily Tribune*, a source of income for the next decade.
- **April 6, 1855** Marx’s best-loved son, eight-year-old Edgar, dies; in all, four of Marx’s seven children die between 1850 and 1857.
- **October 1864** Elected to the General Council of the International Working Men’s Association (the First International).
- **1867** Volume one of his masterpiece, *Das Kapital*, is published.
- **1868** Marx and the anarchist Bakunin begin a struggle for control of the First International.
- **1871** Marx writes *The Civil War in France* after the crushing of the Paris Commune uprising.
- **September 1872** At the Hague Congress of the First International, the followers of Bakunin quit the organization; the seat of the International is moved to New York, where it goes into decline.
- **December 2, 1881** Marx’s wife Jenny dies.
- **March 14, 1883** Marx dies; he is buried in Highgate Cemetery, London.



JENNY MARX, C. 1840